



Mindful Diabetes Inc.

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Free Health Guide

7 Days of DASH

Grocery List, Sodium Swaps & Simple Meal Builder

A practical way to explore DASH one meal, grocery choice, and habit at a time.

Start with one useful change.

Evidence-informed education. Not individualized medical advice.



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What is DASH?

A flexible eating pattern - not a purity test.

DASH stands for Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension. It was originally studied as a dietary pattern for blood-pressure reduction and is built around everyday foods rather than a special product or strict meal plan.

DASH is a pattern - not a purity test.

Frozen vegetables count. Canned beans count. Affordable store brands count. Restaurant meals and culturally familiar foods can fit.

Generally emphasizes

- ☐ Vegetables and fruit
- ☐ Whole grains
- ☐ Beans and lentils
- ☐ Nuts and seeds
- ☐ Lower-fat dairy when appropriate
- ☐ Fish, poultry and lean proteins
- ☐ Vegetable oils and unsaturated fats

Generally limits

- ☐ Excessive sodium
- ☐ Foods high in saturated fat
- ☐ Heavily processed foods
- ☐ Sugar-sweetened beverages
- ☐ Frequent high-sodium foods

What the science says

Strongest evidence

Blood pressure. Randomized trials consistently show DASH-style patterns can reduce blood pressure.

Supportive evidence

Cardiometabolic health. Research suggests potential improvements in LDL cholesterol, weight, or waist circumference in some groups.

More variable

Blood glucose and insulin. DASH can fit diabetes care, but direct glucose and insulin effects are less consistent across trials.

Do not overstate glycemic benefits. Use DASH as a flexible framework, not a promise.

Start at the grocery store

Fresh, frozen, canned, and affordable store brands can all work.



Vegetables

- ☐ Frozen vegetables
- ☐ Leafy greens
- ☐ Broccoli, carrots, peppers
- ☐ Tomatoes and onions
- ☐ No-salt-added canned vegetables

Fruit

- ☐ Apples, bananas, citrus
- ☐ Berries
- ☐ Seasonal fruit
- ☐ Frozen unsweetened fruit

Whole grains & fiber-rich carbohydrates

- ☐ Oats
- ☐ Brown rice
- ☐ Whole-grain bread or wraps
- ☐ Whole-grain pasta
- ☐ Potatoes or sweet potatoes
- ☐ Culturally familiar grains

Beans & lentils

- ☐ Black beans, chickpeas
- ☐ Lentils or kidney beans
- ☐ Other legumes
- ☐ Compare sodium or rinse canned beans

Protein

- ☐ Fish
- ☐ Chicken or turkey
- ☐ Eggs
- ☐ Beans/lentils
- ☐ Plain yogurt
- ☐ Lower-sodium canned fish

Nuts, seeds & fats

- ☐ Unsalted nuts
- ☐ Seeds
- ☐ Peanut or nut butter
- ☐ Olive oil
- ☐ Avocado

Flavor builders

- ☐ Garlic, lemon/lime
- ☐ Vinegar, pepper, herbs
- ☐ Paprika, cumin, chili
- ☐ Salt-free seasoning blends

Carbohydrates are not inherently unhealthy. For diabetes care, portions may need to be individualized.

Don't memorize foods. Compare them.

Use the label, the serving size, and the amount you actually eat.

Much of the sodium people eat comes from packaged foods, restaurant foods, sauces, breads, deli meats, soups, snacks, and prepared meals - not only from the salt shaker.

DASH sodium reference points

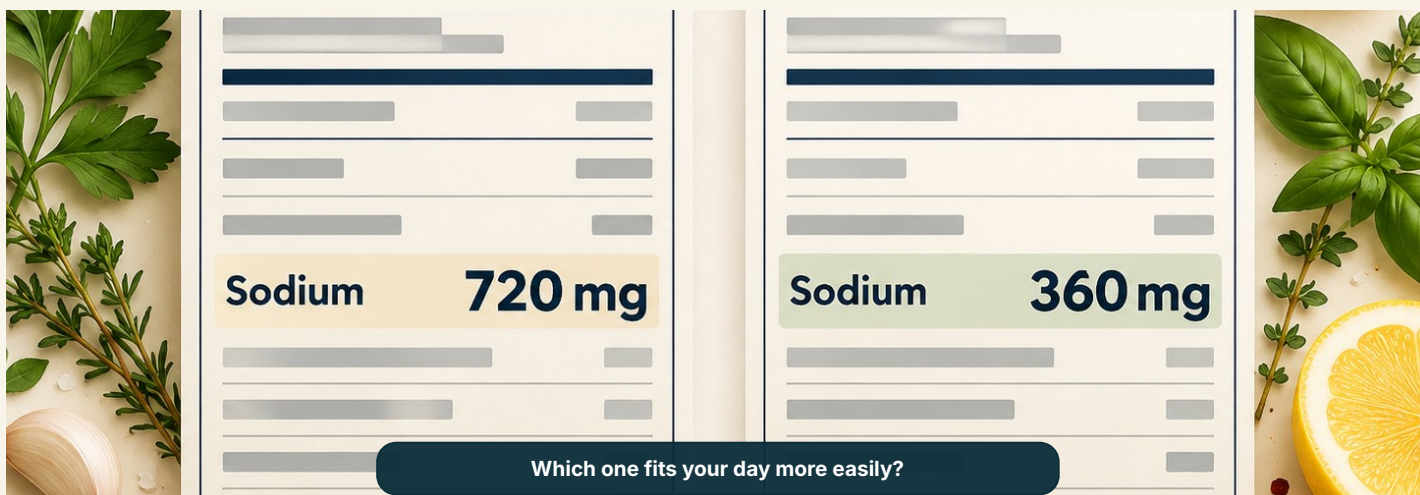
2,300 mg/day

commonly used standard DASH sodium limit

1,500 mg/day

may lower blood pressure further for some people

These are reference levels - not individualized prescriptions. Your medical needs may differ.



You do not need to declare one food good and the other bad. The point is to understand the tradeoff.

10 realistic sodium swaps

- ☐ Regular canned beans
→ lower-sodium or rinsed beans
- ☐ Regular broth
→ reduced-sodium broth
- ☐ Heavy bottled sauce
→ smaller portion or lower-sodium version
- ☐ Deli meat every day
→ rotate with eggs, beans, tuna, leftovers
- ☐ Salt-heavy blend
→ herbs + spices + citrus
- ☐ Salted nuts
→ unsalted or lightly salted nuts
- ☐ Restaurant sauce poured over
→ sauce on the side when practical
- ☐ Instant flavored grains
→ plain grains + your own seasonings
- ☐ High-sodium frozen entree
→ compare similar options
- ☐ Large sodium-heavy portion
→ smaller serving + vegetables/protein

Build the meal you already like

A DASH-friendly meal can be a bowl, curry, taco, soup, sandwich, family recipe, or restaurant meal.



1 Vegetables

Start with vegetables when available.

2 Protein

Beans, lentils, fish, poultry, eggs, yogurt, or another protein.

3 Carbohydrate

Whole grains, potatoes, beans, fruit, bread, tortillas, rice, or staples that fit.

4 Flavor + healthy fats

Olive oil, avocado, nuts, seeds, herbs, citrus, and spices.

5 Beverage

Water, sparkling water, unsweetened tea, or lower-sugar options.

DASH is not inherently a low-carbohydrate diet.

For people with diabetes, carbohydrate amount and portions may need to be individualized.

Four real-world DASH-style meals

Salmon bowl

Salmon + roasted vegetables + brown rice + yogurt sauce

Bean tacos

Beans + cabbage + tomato + avocado + corn tortillas

Chicken stir-fry

Chicken + vegetables + rice + herbs/spices

Lentil curry

Lentils + vegetables + whole grain or rice + yogurt

Choose a familiar meal. Add one useful DASH-related step.

Seven days. Seven experiments.

This is not a challenge to be perfect. Each day is one small experiment.

1

Add a fruit

Add one fruit you genuinely enjoy to a meal or snack you already eat. Do not change anything else unless you want to.

5

Add nuts or seeds

Try walnuts, almonds, peanuts, pumpkin seeds, chia, or flax. Choose unsalted or lightly salted if appropriate.

2

Add a vegetable

Add one vegetable to a meal. Fresh, frozen, canned, cooked, raw, or leftover all count.

6

Run a sodium experiment

Choose one food you buy frequently. Ask: How much sodium is in the amount I actually eat?

3

Compare a grain

Look at one grain or bread you buy. Compare fiber, sodium, and serving size.

7

Build one complete meal

Try vegetables + protein + carbohydrate + satisfying flavor + lower-sugar beverage. Celebrate the practice.

4

Try beans or lentils

Use them in tacos, soup, salad, curry, rice, pasta, or a bowl. They do not have to replace meat completely.

You have not completed DASH.

You practiced seven useful DASH-related behaviors.

No judgment. Just information, practice, and one small next step.

What happens after Day 7?

Pick one or two changes that felt easiest and repeat them.

Next habits to repeat

- ☐ Add vegetables to one regular meal
- ☐ Compare sodium on one recurring food
- ☐ Eat beans or lentils once or twice per week
- ☐ Keep fruit somewhere easy to see
- ☐ Use herbs, citrus, vinegar and spices
- ☐ Build one DASH-style meal each week

When DASH may need individualization

Talk with an appropriate healthcare professional or registered dietitian before intentionally increasing potassium intake or using potassium-based salt substitutes if you:

- ☐ have chronic kidney disease
- ☐ restrict potassium
- ☐ take medicines affecting potassium
- ☐ have sodium or fluid restrictions
- ☐ have other medical dietary requirements

If you live with diabetes

A DASH-style eating pattern can be adapted to diabetes care. There is no single DASH carbohydrate target that works for everyone. Carbohydrate quantity, meal timing, medication, activity, glucose response, culture, preferences, and other factors can influence what works best.

Never change prescribed medications based only on this guide.

Keep learning with Mindful Diabetes

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mindfuldiabetes.org/dash-diet/

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Scientific references

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Educational purposes only. This guide is not individualized medical advice and does not replace care from a qualified healthcare professional. Dietary needs can differ based on health conditions, medications, allergies, culture, access, and personal preferences.